

Introduction

The medieval period was a time of religious change across Europe and western Asia. When the Germanic leader Odoacer conquered Rome in 476 CE, the Roman Empire that had dominated the region for a thousand years finally disintegrated. In its wake, two mighty new religions, Christianity and Islam, arose and in time dominated all others—Christianity in the West and Islam in the East.

To both religions, ancient magical traditions seemed to challenge their authority and beliefs. Magic practitioners of all levels, from high priests and priestesses to monks and village healers or herdsmen, had often been the most revered figures in society. Now, however, they found themselves increasingly marginalized.

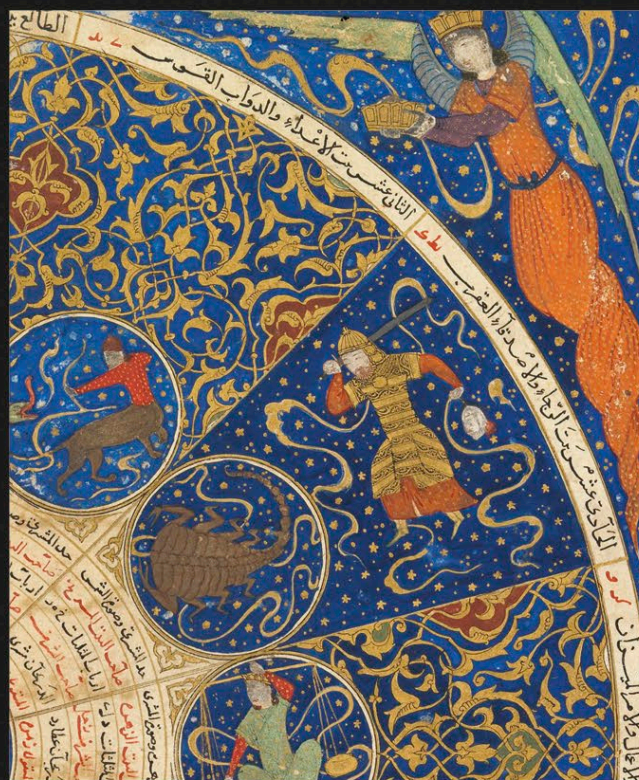
As Christianity spread north and west, high ceremonial magic, at least, was increasingly driven underground, or pushed to the far fringes of the Celtic and Viking worlds where pagan beliefs held fast for

many centuries. Supernatural powers such as control of the elements and the weather—so important in rural farming communities—were appropriated by the Church for saints. In the meantime, powerful practitioners of magic were literally demonized: they were portrayed as owing their abilities to the Devil. They were described as practicing *sortilegium* (sorcery) or *maleficium* (evil deeds). The punishments for such practices became severe. In 789 CE, for instance, the Emperor Charlemagne issued the General Admonition, whereby sorcerers and enchanters were condemned to death.

For many centuries, however, folk magic was tolerated, and village healers continued to practice much as they had before. Nevertheless, sermons urged people to prayer, and condemned the use of invocations and talismans, or the preparation of potions. Some argued that using the magical powers of herbs and stones was simply drawing on natural



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